MODULE 04 · DOMAIN 1 - PROMPTING AND TASK EXECUTION

Decomposition

When a task is too big for one prompt: how to split it, what order the pieces go in, and when you have split it too far.

DOMAIN 1 of 7 EXAM WEIGHT 14% MODULE 4 of 33

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"Make dinner" is a wish. A recipe is a plan.

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Signals that a task needs breaking down

- **Several distinct outputs.** A timeline, a communications pack and a budget are three jobs.
- **Separate sources or owners.** Finance, operations and HR data, each with its own owner.
- **Steps that depend on each other.** You cannot score before you agree the criteria.
- **A step you must check before the next.** An error early on would spoil everything after it.
- **More than one good answer's worth of work.** Quality drops when one reply tries to do it all.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The strongest signal: the request asks for several different deliverables.

One prompt, or several?

ONE PROMPT IS FINE WHEN

The job is single and short

- One output, one audience
- Inputs fit comfortably
- No step needs checking first
- Easy to review in one read

DECOMPOSE WHEN

The job has parts

- Several deliverables
- Different sources or owners
- Later steps depend on earlier ones
- An early mistake would cascade

THE TIEBREAKER

Several deliverables, or a step you must check before the next: break it down.

Top-down: big picture before detail

01
Objective
What must this achieve, and for whom?

02
Major phases
The few big stages of the work.

03
Steps
What happens inside each phase.

04
Detail
Exact wording, schedules, materials.

ON THE EXAM

Objective and phases come before any detailed content. Detail written first gets rewritten.

Dependencies decide the order

Choosing three sites to pilot a new digital timesheet

STEP	IT NEEDS FIRST
1. Agree the selection criteria	The pilot's purpose
2. Gather each site's data	The criteria, so you know what to collect
3. Score the sites	The criteria and the data
4. Shortlist and recommend	The scores

THE TIEBREAKER

Ask of every step: what must already exist before this can start?

Many owners: one section at a time

- **Agree the report's goals and audience** before anything is drafted.
- **Gather each section's inputs** from the person who owns them.
- **Draft each section in its own prompt**, with only that section's material.
- **Check each section with its owner.** They know if a figure looks wrong.
- **Write the executive summary last**, from the finished sections.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A summary written before the sections summarises a report that does not exist yet.

Chaining prompts, and checking between them

- **A chain:** each prompt does one job, and its output feeds the next.
- **Draft, review, refine** is the most common chain, says Anthropic.
- **The gap between links is where you check.** Catch an error before it travels.
- **Currency check:** newer models handle more in one go, so chain when you need to inspect a step.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Chain when an intermediate result needs a human look. Otherwise, one strong prompt may do.

Too far: when decomposition backfires

OVER-DECOMPOSED

Eighteen tiny prompts

- One prompt per paragraph
- Ideas split from their reasons
- Repetition and gaps
- Reads like eighteen authors

RIGHT-SIZED

Four cohesive sections

- Split where the work separates
- Connected ideas stay together
- One owner per section
- A final pass for flow

THE TIEBREAKER

Split where the work naturally separates. Keep connected ideas in the same piece.

The 300-page tender, decomposed

01
Extract
Questions, mandatory items, scoring rules.

02
Check
A person confirms the checklist.

03
Draft
Each answer against its criteria.

04
Review
Drafts against the checklist.

05
Assemble
Then write the cover summary.

ON THE EXAM

The checklist is the intermediate output worth checking: everything later depends on it.

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Five decomposition patterns worth knowing

KIND OF JOB	THE ORDER
Evaluation or selection	Criteria, then data, then scoring, then ranking
Research	Questions, then sources, then findings, then synthesis
Process redesign	Objective, then phases, then steps, then materials
Multi-owner report	Goals, then sections, then checks, then summary last
Creative work	Frame, then generate, then evaluate, then refine

ON THE EXAM

Most ordering items on decomposition fit one of these five shapes.

> Four requests reach Halden's operations team on the same morning. Each will go to Claude.
>
> The team lead wants to know which one will benefit most from being broken into separate steps.

Which request most benefits from decomposition?

A Rewrite one paragraph of a client letter in plain English

B Translate a short safety notice for field staff

C Plan the Birmingham hub move: a timeline, a staff communications pack and a budget

D Summarise a two-page complaint letter from a client

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which request most benefits from decomposition?

A Rewrite one paragraph of a client letter in plain English

One output, one short input. A single prompt is ideal.

B Translate a short safety notice for field staff

A single, well-defined transformation.

C Plan the Birmingham hub move: a timeline, a staff communications pack and a budget

Three distinct deliverables, and the budget depends on the timeline.

D Summarise a two-page complaint letter from a client

Short input, one output. No parts to separate.

THE SIGNAL

Three different deliverables in one request: the clearest decomposition signal.

> Halden will pilot a new digital timesheet at three of its 260 sites. A manager plans to use Claude to help choose them.
>
> The choice must be defensible to the regional directors, who will ask why their sites were or were not picked.

Which sequence is sound?

A. Agree the selection criteria, gather each site's data against them, then score and shortlist

B. Gather all available site data, choose criteria that suit it, then shortlist

C. Ask Claude for a shortlist, then agree criteria that justify it

D. Score the sites on the data to hand, then agree criteria, then fill gaps

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

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Which sequence is sound?

A Agree the selection criteria, gather each site's data against them, then score and shortlist

Each step has what it needs. Defensible because criteria came first.

B Gather all available site data, choose criteria that suit it, then shortlist

Criteria shaped by convenient data, not by the pilot's purpose.

C Ask Claude for a shortlist, then agree criteria that justify it

Justifying a conclusion after the fact. Indefensible.

D Score the sites on the data to hand, then agree criteria, then fill gaps

Scoring before criteria exist means scoring against nothing.

THE SIGNAL

"Must be defensible": criteria first, so the outcome follows from them.

Halden's annual review for its largest client has finance, operations and satisfaction sections, each owned by a different manager.

(1) Draft the executive summary from the finished sections.

(2) Agree the review's goals and audience with the account director.

(3) Draft each section in its own prompt, with that section's data.

(4) Gather each section's data from its owner.

(5) Check each drafted section with its owner.

What is the correct order?

A 4, 2, 3, 1, 5

B 2, 3, 4, 5, 1

C 2, 4, 1, 3, 5

D 2, 4, 3, 5, 1

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the correct order?

A 4, 2, 3, 1, 5

Gathers data before anyone agreed what the review is for.

B 2, 3, 4, 5, 1

Drafts sections before their data has been gathered.

C 2, 4, 1, 3, 5

Writes the summary before the sections exist.

D 2, 4, 3, 5, 1

Goals, data, drafts, owner checks, then the summary last.

THE SIGNAL

Anchor the ends first: goals open it, the summary closes it.

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A Halden manager writing a safety-culture strategy split it into eighteen prompts, one per paragraph, to keep each answer focused.

The assembled draft repeats itself, separates several ideas from their reasons, and reads as if many people wrote it.

What is the best adjustment?

A Split it further, with one prompt per sentence for tighter control

B Regroup into a few cohesive sections of connected ideas, then do a final pass for flow

C Merge all eighteen instructions into one very long prompt

D Ask Claude to add linking phrases between the eighteen paragraphs

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the best adjustment?

A Split it further, with one prompt per sentence for tighter control

Makes the fragmentation worse.

B Regroup into a few cohesive sections of connected ideas, then do a final pass for flow

Splits where the work separates and keeps related ideas together.

C Merge all eighteen instructions into one very long prompt

Overcorrects. Loses the benefit of focused sections.

D Ask Claude to add linking phrases between the eighteen paragraphs

Cosmetic. Repetition and orphaned reasons remain.

THE SIGNAL

Repetition and ideas cut from their reasons: the pieces are too small.

> Halden's marketing team wants Claude to generate concepts for a campaign to recruit field cleaners in the South region.
>
> Nobody has yet written anything down about what the campaign is for.

Which step must come before asking Claude for concepts?

A Choose the two strongest concepts to show the board

B Book the photographer for the campaign shoot

C Agree the campaign's goal, the applicants it targets and how success is measured

D Ask Claude to rate each concept it produces

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which step must come before asking Claude for concepts?

A Choose the two strongest concepts to show the board

Selection happens after generation, not before.

B Book the photographer for the campaign shoot

Execution detail, long after concepts are chosen.

C Agree the campaign's goal, the applicants it targets and how success is measured

Framing first: concepts need a target to aim at.

D Ask Claude to rate each concept it produces

Evaluation, which follows generation.

THE SIGNAL

Frame, generate, evaluate, refine. Framing is the only step that comes before.

> Halden's bid team must answer a 300-page tender with forty questions. Last time, one answer missed a mandatory requirement and the bid was marked down.
>
> The team wants to use Claude, and to avoid repeating that mistake.

Which approach best reduces the risk?

A Give Claude the whole tender and ask for all forty answers at once, then read them

B Extract a checklist of questions, mandatory items and scoring rules, check it, then draft each answer against it

C Use research mode to see how other firms answered similar tenders

D Tell Claude to be especially careful about mandatory requirements

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

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Which approach best reduces the risk?

A Give Claude the whole tender and ask for all forty answers at once, then read them

No intermediate check. A missed requirement hides in forty answers.

B Extract a checklist of questions, mandatory items and scoring rules, check it, then draft each answer against it

Creates a checkable intermediate step that every answer is held to.

C Use research mode to see how other firms answered similar tenders

Other firms' answers say nothing about this tender's requirements.

D Tell Claude to be especially careful about mandatory requirements

An exhortation, not a control. Nothing can be checked.

THE SIGNAL

The failure was a missed requirement. The fix is a checked list of requirements.

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In five lines

- **Decompose** when there are several deliverables, owners or dependent steps.
- **Top-down:** objective, then phases, then steps, then detail.
- **Dependencies decide order.** Criteria before data before scoring.
- **Many owners:** a prompt per section, owner checks, summary last.
- **Do not over-split.** Keep connected ideas together; check between links.

COMING UP

Next: iterating well, and matching your prompting strategy to the task.